

FEDERAL LAUNCH KIT · 01 SAM.GOV

SAM.gov, Registered Right.

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- ✓ **Common Fixes** · IRS mismatch, CAGE delays, EFT errors
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THE FOUR-TOOL SYSTEM

FREE · LETTER PDF

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Pre-reg to renewal, every click

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IRS mismatch, CAGE delays,
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Stay active past day 365

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Six phases. One registration.

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A LETTER TO THE OPERATOR

SAM.gov isn't hard. It's just unforgiving.

The first SAM registration I ran on behalf of a client took 41 days. Not because the form was complicated. Because the legal name on their incorporation paperwork said 'Inc.' and the IRS file said 'Inc'. One period. Six weeks of validation failures and three calls to the IRS Business Line before anyone caught it.

Most people treat SAM like a tax form — fill it out fast, hit submit, hope for the best. That's why 30% of first-time registrations fail validation on the first try. The fix is the opposite: slow down on the boring fields, get the identifiers right before you log in, and don't touch the form until you've gathered every piece of paper on the checklist.

This walkthrough is the version I wish we'd had on day one. Six phases. Every field that matters. The watch-outs that cost people weeks. Real fix paths for the six most common failure modes.

Read it once before you start. Keep it open in a tab while you register. You'll be active in 7 to 14 days instead of six weeks.

A. Schuler

30 MIN · NO PITCH

Book a 30-min SAM walk-through

<https://meetings-na2.hubspot.com/american/intro-call>

Book the call →

ORIENTATION

Two things to know **before** you touch the site.

SAM.gov is the single front door for everyone doing business with the US federal government. Grants, contracts, sub-awards, payments — they all route through your active SAM registration. No active registration, no eligibility, no payment.

It's also free. If a search result, a LinkedIn DM, or a phone call says you need to pay to register, walk away. The next two pages cover what the system actually is, what you need to gather first, and the timeline you're really looking at.

G01 • ORIENTATION

What SAM is, what it isn't, and the only URL that's real.

The System for Award Management (SAM.gov) is the federal government's single registration system for entities doing business with any agency. One record, one UEI, one CAGE code — used by every contracting officer, grant manager, and payment system in the federal stack.

THE SCAM CHECK

SAM.gov is free. Always. If anyone — a service, a consultant, a 'registration agent' — charges you to register or renew, it's a scam. The only official URL is **sam.gov**. Not sam.net. Not sam-gov.org. Not us-sam.com. Type the URL directly. Don't click ads.

Your three timelines.

STAGE	TIME	WHAT'S HAPPENING
Setup	6–12 hours	Gathering documents, completing the form. Spread this over 2–3 days so you don't make tired mistakes on legally binding answers.
Activation	7–14 business days	IRS validates your EIN. SAM requests your CAGE code from DLA. Both run in parallel after you submit.
Renewal	Every 365 days	Annual recertification. Miss it and your registration goes inactive — no payments, no new awards until you fix it.

What an active SAM record gets you.

- **Eligibility** to bid on every federal contract and apply for every federal grant.
- **A UEI** (Unique Entity Identifier) — your 12-character permanent ID across the federal government.
- **A CAGE code** — 5-character identifier issued by Defense Logistics Agency, required for DoD work.
- **A bank record** the government uses to wire payments. This is also the field fraudsters target — see page 30.

G02 • ORIENTATION

Gather these before you log in.

Half of SAM registrations stall because someone hits a required field, realizes they don't have the answer, and pauses for a week. Pull every item on this list onto your desk before you create the login.gov account. The form takes about 90 minutes if you have the answers. Two weeks if you don't.

Documents

ITEM	WHERE TO FIND IT	WHY IT MATTERS
IRS EIN Letter (CP 575 or 147C)	Your tax records, or call IRS Business Line at 800-829-4933 for a replacement	Your legal entity name on SAM must match this letter EXACTLY. One period out of place causes validation failure.
State formation documents	State Secretary of State filing	Confirms your business structure (LLC, S-Corp, partnership, sole prop) and legal name.
Bank routing + account numbers	A voided check or your bank's website	Electronic Funds Transfer (EFT) is how the government pays you. Wrong number, wrong payee.
Fiscal year end date	Your accountant or tax return	Required for the Core Data section. Most calendar-year businesses use December 31.

Decisions to make first

- **Primary NAICS code.** This determines your size standard. Pick the code that best matches your largest revenue stream. You can list 2–6 codes total — see the NAICS section on page 16.
- **Socioeconomic status.** Are you a small business under the SBA size standard for your primary NAICS? Are you also veteran-owned, woman-owned, HUBZone, 8(a), or service-disabled veteran-owned? Have your supporting documentation ready.
- **Who's the government POC?** This becomes your public contact for federal agencies. Use a shared inbox like *contracts@yourcompany.com*, not a personal email.

FIELD TIP

Print this page. Tick each item off in pen before you create the login.gov account. It's the difference between 90 minutes of focused work and three weeks of half-finished sessions.

PART ONE • GETTING IN

Two phases. Done **right**, you're registered in a week.

Phase 1 is the pre-flight check — every identifier, every document, every decision you'll need before the form opens. Phase 2 is creating the login.gov account that is the front door to SAM and dozens of other federal systems.

Skip either of these and you'll end up filling out the form three times. The next few pages walk through both with the specific click paths and watch-outs.

P01 • PHASE 1

Pre-Registration Setup — the checklist that decides your timeline.

Complete every item below before you touch SAM.gov. Each one is a required field somewhere in the form. Missing answers force you to abandon a half-filled session and start over.

The six-item checklist

ITEM	DETAIL	WATCH OUT FOR
1. UEI (Unique Entity Identifier)	New entities receive a UEI automatically during SAM registration. No separate step. DUNS numbers were retired in April 2022.	If you registered before April 2022, your existing UEI carries over. Don't apply for a new one.
2. EIN (Employer Identification Number)	From the IRS. Sole proprietors can use SSN but EIN is strongly preferred for privacy and continuity.	The legal name attached to this EIN at the IRS must match the legal name you enter in SAM exactly.
3. NAICS codes (2–6)	Your primary NAICS determines your small business size standard. Add secondary codes for related work you do.	Pick primary by revenue, not aspiration. A wrong primary can flip your size status from small to large.
4. Banking information	ABA routing number + account number for EFT. The government uses this to pay you.	If a fraudster changes this later, your payments go to them. Lock this record (see page 30).
5. Fiscal year end date	Month and day. Most businesses use 12/31.	Must match what you report to the IRS.
6. Business structure	LLC, S-Corp, C-Corp, partnership, sole proprietorship, etc.	If you converted recently, use your current structure, not the one from incorporation.

EIN VERIFICATION

Call IRS Business Line at 800-829-4933 BEFORE you start. Ask them to read back your exact legal name as it appears in their EIN records. Write it down character-for-character including punctuation and capitalization. This single call prevents the most common SAM rejection.

P01 • PHASE 1 (CONTINUED)

NAICS, size, and the call you'll make to your accountant.

Picking your primary NAICS

Your primary NAICS code is the most consequential decision in this section. It sets your size standard — the revenue or headcount threshold below which you qualify as a small business. Small business eligibility is the gateway to roughly 23% of all federal contract dollars set aside specifically for small firms.

INDUSTRY	NAICS EXAMPLES	SIZE STANDARD
IT Services	541511 (Custom Software), 541512 (Computer Systems Design)	\$34M average revenue (3-year)
Janitorial	561720 (Janitorial Services)	\$22M average revenue
Construction	236220 (Commercial Construction)	\$45M average revenue
Professional Services	541611 (Management Consulting)	\$24.5M average revenue
Manufacturing	varies by product	Usually 500 or 1,000 employees

Calculating your size

For revenue-based NAICS, SBA uses your **3-year average annual receipts**. For employee-based NAICS, it's the average number of employees per pay period over the last 12 months. If you're under both thresholds you're small. If you're over, you're not — and you lose set-aside eligibility under that NAICS.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Get your accountant to calculate your 3-year average receipts and your 12-month average headcount before you start the form. Document the calculation. You'll re-certify these numbers annually — and the IRS or SBA can audit them.

Banking — the EFT setup

Find a voided check or log into your business bank account. You need:

- **ABA routing number** — 9 digits, identifies the bank.
- **Account number** — your specific account at that bank.
- **Account type** — checking or savings.

Type these directly from the source. Do not copy from a year-old document. Banks change routing numbers when they merge, and an old routing number means failed payments.

P02 • PHASE 2

Create your login.gov account — the federal single sign-on.

SAM.gov uses login.gov for authentication. So do IRS Direct File, USAJobs, MyMedicare, and about 30 other federal services. Create the account carefully; you'll use it for years.

The six-step setup

- 01 **Go to sam.gov.** Click 'Sign In' in the top-right, then 'Create an account'.
- 02 **You'll redirect to login.gov.** This is normal — it's the federal SSO portal that handles authentication for SAM.
- 03 **Enter a shared company email.** Use *admin@yourcompany.com* or *contracts@yourcompany.com*, not a personal address. Create a strong password (16+ characters, mixed case, numbers, symbols).
- 04 **Set up two-factor authentication.** Login.gov requires 2FA — pick the authenticator app option (Google Authenticator, Authy, or 1Password). Do *not* use SMS as your only method; SIM-swap attacks are real.
- 05 **Verify your email.** Click the confirmation link in the email login.gov sends you.
- 06 **Return to sam.gov** and complete the sign-in with your new credentials.

PRO TIP

Save your backup codes. When you enable 2FA, login.gov gives you a list of one-time backup codes. Print them, put them in your safe. If you lose your phone, those codes are the only way back in without a 7-day account recovery process that will lock you out of SAM in the middle of an active solicitation.

Why the shared inbox matters

The email on this login.gov account becomes the federal government's way of reaching you about your SAM record. Password resets, security notices, renewal warnings, and fraud alerts all come here.

If the email belongs to one person — say, the founder who set everything up — and that person leaves the company, you lose access to your SAM record. Recovering it requires notarized identity documentation and weeks of back-and-forth with login.gov support. Use a shared inbox the company controls.

P02 • PHASE 2 (CONTINUED)

Entity Administrator — the role that controls everything.

After login.gov authentication, SAM asks you to claim an Entity Administrator role for your business. The Entity Administrator can edit every field on your registration, including banking. This is a powerful role. Treat it that way.

The Entity Administrator

- **Only one Entity Administrator** per registration is required, but you can appoint multiple users with the role.
- **They control the bank record** — the single most-targeted field by federal payment fraudsters.
- **They can add or remove other users** in the SAM Roles section.
- **Their login.gov account must have 2FA enabled.** SAM enforces this for the Entity Administrator role.

Adding a second admin (recommended)

One admin is a single point of failure. If they leave, lose access, or get phished, your SAM record becomes hard to manage. Best practice:

- 01 The first person registers and claims the Entity Administrator role.
- 02 Within a week, add a second user (CFO, COO, or trusted operations lead) and grant them the Entity Administrator role.
- 03 Both should have authenticator-app 2FA enabled. Document who has the role in your internal runbook.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Federal payment fraud usually starts with a phished Entity Administrator. The attacker logs in with stolen credentials, changes the bank record to their own account, and waits for the next payment. Two admins with 2FA, plus the lockdown steps on page 30, push your record off the easy-target list.

PART TWO • THE REGISTRATION

Three phases. The form itself. The fields that **actually** matter.

Phase 3 is Core Data — the identity layer of your registration. Phase 4 is Reps & Certs, the legally binding section where you certify your size, your status, and your compliance with dozens of FAR clauses. Phase 5 is submission and the parallel validation steps that activate your account.

We'll walk every section, every field, every dropdown that has an answer most people get wrong on the first try.

P03 • PHASE 3

Entity Registration — Core Data section by section.

In SAM.gov, navigate to 'Entity Registration' and click 'Register Entity'. The form walks you through six sections. Each one has fields that trip people up; here's what to enter and what to avoid.

SECTION	KEY FIELDS	WATCH OUT FOR
Purpose of Registration	'All Awards' (most common). Choose this if you want contracts AND grants.	Do NOT select 'IGT' (Intra-Governmental Transactions) unless you're a federal agency. It's the most common mis-pick.
Core Data	Legal business name, physical address (no PO boxes), fiscal year end, business structure, state of incorporation.	Legal name must EXACTLY match IRS records. 'LLC' vs 'L.L.C.' counts as a mismatch.
Assertions	NAICS codes (2–6), PSC codes if applicable, EDI capability, disaster response willingness.	Add every relevant NAICS — not just primary. Buyers search by NAICS, so more = more visibility.
Reps & Certs	Size standards, socioeconomic status, FAR clause representations.	Size is based on your 12-month or 3-year average per NAICS. Be ready to defend the answer.
Points of Contact	Government business POC, electronic business POC, past performance POC.	These become PUBLIC contact info for federal buyers. Use a monitored shared inbox.
Architecture / Disaster	Optional fields about disaster-area presence and tech capability.	Skip if not applicable. Don't over-represent capabilities you can't deliver.

THE LEGAL NAME RULE

Before submitting, open your IRS CP 575 letter and your SAM form side by side. Read both legal names out loud. If a single character differs — including punctuation — fix the SAM entry now. This catches roughly 80% of validation failures before they happen.

P03 • PHASE 3 (CONTINUED)

Points of Contact — the public-facing identity.

SAM requires three Points of Contact. These are not internal-only fields. Federal contracting officers, prime contractors looking for subs, and procurement officers across the government read them when they consider your firm.

The three POCs

POC	WHAT IT'S FOR	BEST PRACTICE
Government Business POC	The federal buyer's first point of contact for capability questions, RFI responses, and award negotiation.	Use your business development lead. Shared inbox preferred. Monitor it daily.
Electronic Business POC	The contact for SAM-related notifications: renewal reminders, fraud alerts, payment notifications, system messages.	Use the same shared inbox as your Entity Administrator. Daily monitoring is critical.
Past Performance POC	The contact for CPARS (Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System) — federal performance ratings on past contracts.	Use someone authorized to respond to CPARS evaluations. These ratings affect future awards.

What buyers see

Type your UEI into SAM.gov's Entity search. The page that comes up — name, address, NAICS, POCs, expiration date — is what every contracting officer sees when they evaluate your offer. Make sure it's accurate, current, and uses contacts you actively monitor.

FIELD TIP

Set up three forwarding rules in your shared inbox: SAM notifications go to operations, capability inquiries go to BD, CPARS notices go to contracts. Same inbox, three workflows, nothing slips.

P03 • PHASE 3 (CONTINUED)

NAICS codes — the more you add, the more buyers find you.

SAM lets you list 2 to 6 NAICS codes. Your primary determines your size standard. Your secondaries determine search visibility — when a contracting officer searches for vendors in a NAICS, they see everyone who lists it on their profile.

How to pick secondaries

- 01 List every NAICS you can credibly deliver.** If you can build websites (541511), you probably also do IT consulting (541512) and maybe digital marketing (541613). Each adds visibility.
- 02 Don't list NAICS you can't deliver.** Bidding on work outside your real capabilities damages your CPARS record and your reputation.
- 03 Re-check size status under each.** Different NAICS have different size standards. You can be small under 541511 (\$34M) and large under 541910 (\$25M) at the same revenue.

NAICS lookup

Use the official Census Bureau NAICS lookup at census.gov/naics. Avoid third-party tools — many are out of date. The SBA size standard for each NAICS is at sba.gov/size-standards.

PRO TIP

Pull your largest competitors' SAM records and copy their NAICS lists. If they're winning work, the NAICS they list are the ones buyers actually search. This is one of the fastest research moves in B2G.

PSC codes (optional but useful)

Product Service Codes (PSCs) are a separate taxonomy used by DoD and a few civilian agencies. If you list relevant PSCs alongside NAICS, you appear in DoD market research searches too. The official list lives at acquisition.gov/psc-manual.

P04 • PHASE 4

Representations & Certifications — the legally binding section.

The Reps & Certs section is where you certify dozens of facts about your business under penalty of False Claims Act exposure. False certifications can trigger debarment, civil penalties up to three times the contract value, and criminal liability for the signers.

This is not a section to rush through.

The clauses that matter most

CLAUSE	WHAT YOU'RE CERTIFYING	WATCH POINTS
FAR 52.219-1 Small Business Program Representations	Your size status under the size standard for your primary NAICS. Based on employee count AND revenue, depending on the NAICS.	Re-calculate this before every offer. If you grew past the threshold, you have 5 days to update your SAM record.
FAR 52.219-8 Utilization of Small Business Concerns	If you're a large business bidding contracts over \$750K, you commit to a subcontracting plan with small business goals.	Required even on Commercial Item contracts above the threshold. Plan must be in eSRS by Oct 30 and Apr 30 each year.
DFARS representations	Defense Federal Acquisition Regulation Supplement clauses for DoD contracts: cybersecurity, supply chain, foreign ownership.	Required if you plan to bid on any Department of Defense work. The cybersecurity reps tie to CMMC compliance.
Socioeconomic certifications	8(a), HUBZone, WOSB/EDWOSB, SDVOSB, VOSB status.	8(a) and HUBZone require SBA approval first. SDVOSB/VOSB require CVE verification. WOSB/EDWOSB can be self-certified in SAM but must be supported by documents in WOSB Certification.

P04 • PHASE 4 (CONTINUED)

Size standards — the calculation that decides your eligibility.

Your small business status under each NAICS code is the single most-checked fact about your firm. Get it right; document the math.

Two ways size is measured

TYPE	HOW IT'S CALCULATED	WHERE IT APPLIES
Revenue-based	Average annual receipts over the last 3 completed fiscal years.	Services, retail, most professional firms. Example: 541511 = \$34M cap.
Employee-based	Average number of employees per pay period over the last 12 months. Includes full-time, part-time, and temporary.	Manufacturing, wholesale, mining. Example: many manufacturing NAICS = 500 or 1,000 employees.

Affiliation — the rule that catches everyone

Your size includes your affiliates. SBA considers another firm an affiliate if you share ownership, management, common identity of interest, or if one party has the power to control the other. This means:

- **If you own another business** in a related industry, its revenue counts toward your size.
- **If a private equity firm owns you** and also owns competitors, you might all be aggregated.
- **Joint ventures** are exempt under specific SBA rules (Mentor-Protégé program), but most other partnerships count as affiliation.

PRO TIP

Document your size calculation in a one-page memo signed by your CFO. Date it. Re-do the memo every fiscal year. If SBA challenges your size in a protest, this memo is your defense. Without it, every certification is at risk.

What happens if you outgrow size

If your 3-year average revenue or your headcount crosses the threshold, you must update your SAM record within 5 business days. You can finish performing contracts you already won as a small business — but you can't bid new small business set-asides under that NAICS.

P04 • PHASE 4 (CONTINUED)

Socioeconomic certifications — which need pre-approval, which don't.

SAM lets you self-certify some socioeconomic statuses inside the form. Others require formal approval from SBA or VA before SAM will accept the claim. Knowing which is which prevents 30-day rejection cycles.

STATUS	SELF-CERT IN SAM?	WHERE TO APPLY
Small Business	Yes — based on size standard	SAM directly. Recalculate annually.
WOSB / EDWOSB Woman-Owned / Economically Disadvantaged Woman-Owned	Yes, but only after uploading docs to certify.sba.gov	certify.sba.gov — upload ownership and control documentation.
HUBZone	No — requires SBA approval first	certify.sba.gov. Approval takes 60–90 days. 35% of employees must live in a HUBZone.
8(a) Business Development	No — requires SBA approval and a 9-year program enrollment	certify.sba.gov. Strict ownership requirements; net worth and income caps apply.
SDVOSB / VOSB Service-Disabled / Veteran-Owned	No — requires VA CVE verification	VetCert at va.gov/osdbu/verification . New process as of 2023.

Common rejections

- **WOSB without certify.sba.gov upload:** Self-certifying in SAM without the SBA repository upload is no longer valid. Documents must be on file at certify.sba.gov.
- **HUBZone claim before approval:** SBA rejects the SAM record. You wait 60 days, then re-submit.
- **Veteran-owned without VA CVE:** As of 2023, only VA-verified firms can claim SDVOSB or VOSB. Self-certification is gone.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Federal set-asides are worth roughly \$160B per year. Most of that flows to firms with verified socioeconomic status. Get the underlying approval before you claim the status in SAM, not after.

P05 • PHASE 5

Submit and Activate — what happens in the next 7–14 days.

Once you click submit, two validation steps run in parallel. Most rejections happen here. Both steps complete automatically — no further action on your part unless one fails.

The four things that happen after submit

STEP	TIMING	WHAT'S HAPPENING
1. IRS Validation	1–3 business days	SAM sends your EIN + legal name to the IRS. The IRS checks for an exact match against their records. This is the #1 cause of delays.
2. CAGE Code Assignment	3–5 business days	If you don't have a CAGE code, SAM automatically requests one from DLA (Defense Logistics Agency). DLA assigns the 5-character code and returns it.
3. UEI Assignment	Immediate	Your 12-character Unique Entity Identifier is assigned the moment you submit. Save this. It's permanent.
4. Active Status	7–14 business days total	Full activation comes by email once IRS and CAGE both clear. Your registration is then 'Active' and visible to all federal agencies.

COMMON IRS MISMATCH FIX

If your registration fails IRS validation, compare your legal entity name in SAM EXACTLY to what's on your IRS CP 575 letter. Even 'Inc.' vs 'Inc' can cause a mismatch. Call IRS Business Line at 800-829-4933 to confirm the exact name they have on file. Update SAM to match. Resubmit. Validation usually clears within 24 hours of the fix.

P05 • PHASE 5 (CONTINUED)

CAGE Code — the DoD identifier you didn't know you needed.

CAGE stands for Commercial and Government Entity. It's a 5-character alphanumeric code assigned by the Defense Logistics Agency. Every entity doing business with DoD has one. SAM requests one automatically the first time you register.

What CAGE does

- Identifies your firm in DoD procurement systems (DLA, NAVSEA, USACE, Air Force, etc.).
- Required for DFARS work — Department of Defense contracts and most DoD subcontracts.
- Used in FedBizOpps and Wide Area Workflow (WAWF) for invoice routing and payment.
- Permanent — your CAGE code never changes, even if you move or restructure.

What can go wrong

ISSUE	CAUSE	FIX
CAGE assignment taking more than 5 days	DLA backlog or data discrepancy	Call DLA CAGE help desk at 1-877-352-2255 with your SAM request ID.
Existing CAGE code not recognized	SAM didn't link your prior code; usually caused by an address mismatch.	Email cagemail@dla.mil with your UEI, legal name, and CAGE code. They'll re-link.
Wrong address on CAGE record	You moved and updated SAM but not DLA	Submit a CAGE update via the SAM CAGE change request. DLA validates within 5 days.

WHY THIS MATTERS

No CAGE code means no DoD payment. Wide Area Workflow uses CAGE to route invoices to the right payment shop. A wrong or missing CAGE turns a 30-day payment cycle into a 90-day one.

P05 • PHASE 5 (CONTINUED)

Pre-submit checklist — the last review before you click.

Before you hit submit, walk this list. Each item catches a common rejection. Spending 15 minutes here saves you a 14-day delay.

The 12-point pre-submit review

- 01 **Legal entity name** matches IRS CP 575 letter character-for-character (including punctuation and capitalization).
- 02 **EIN** matches the EIN on the CP 575 letter.
- 03 **Physical address** is a real street address, not a PO box or virtual office.
- 04 **Fiscal year end** matches what your accountant reports to the IRS.
- 05 **Business structure** is current (LLC vs S-Corp vs sole prop), not what you started as.
- 06 **Primary NAICS** reflects your largest revenue stream.
- 07 **Secondary NAICS codes** include every NAICS you can credibly deliver under.
- 08 **Size status** calculated with a CFO-signed memo backing it up.
- 09 **Socioeconomic certs** have backing SBA / VA approvals where required.
- 10 **Banking info** typed directly from a voided check or your bank's website.
- 11 **POC emails** all use shared inboxes the company controls.
- 12 **Two Entity Administrators** set up, both with 2FA enabled.

THE COFFEE TEST

Don't submit at the end of a long session. Save your progress. Walk away. Come back the next morning with coffee and re-read every field before you click. Fatigue is the leading cause of mis-entered legal names — and IRS validation doesn't forgive typos.

PART THREE • STAYING ACTIVE

Submission is the **easy** part. Staying active is the work.

Once SAM activates your registration, you have a 365-day countdown. Miss renewal and you go inactive — no new awards, no payments on existing contracts, no eligibility. Many small primes have lost weeks of work because nobody calendared the renewal.

Part Three covers the post-registration housekeeping that protects you: backup your records, calendar renewals, harden your account against fraud, and clear common troubleshooting issues fast.

P06 • PHASE 6

Post-Registration — the six things to do in week one.

Your activation email is the start, not the finish. The next six tasks lock in everything you just built and put you in the buyer's market.

The week-one checklist

TASK	WHY	HOW LONG
Download your Entity Registration Summary PDF	Your proof of registration. Many primes ask for this when adding you as a sub. Save it in your contracts folder and your shared drive.	5 minutes
Set a calendar reminder for renewal	365 days from activation. Set it 60 days early so you have time to gather updated docs. Put it on a shared calendar, not personal.	2 minutes
Update your capability statement	Add your new UEI and CAGE code. Re-export. Buyers expect both.	15 minutes
Register at sam.gov/opportunities	The federal contract opportunities database. Set up email alerts for your NAICS so you see Sources Sought and Solicitations as they post.	10 minutes
Apply for socioeconomic certifications	If you qualify, SDVOSB via VetCert, WOSB via certify.sba.gov , 8(a) via SBA Connect. Each unlocks a separate set-aside market.	2–8 hours per cert
Set up your USASpending.gov entity profile	Tracks every dollar the government has paid you. Useful for past performance documentation and pricing intelligence on competitors.	20 minutes

P06 • PHASE 6 (CONTINUED)

Opportunity alerts — the first revenue play after activation.

Once your record is active, sam.gov/opportunities is where federal demand shows up. Sources Sought notices appear 6 to 18 months before a Solicitation. Pre-Solicitation notices appear 3 to 6 months before. Solicitations themselves give you 15 to 45 days to respond. Getting the alerts right means seeing demand early.

Setting up alerts

- 01 Log into sam.gov with your login.gov account.
- 02 Click 'Opportunities' in the top nav.
- 03 Build a search: enter NAICS codes, agencies, geographies, and keywords that fit your firm.
- 04 Save the search. Toggle email notifications to **Daily**.
- 05 Set up separate saved searches for each NAICS and each notice type (Sources Sought, Pre-Solicitation, Solicitation, Award Notice).

Notice types — what each means

NOTICE TYPE	LEAD TIME	WHAT TO DO
Sources Sought / RFI	6–18 months before award	Respond with your capability statement. This is how you shape the eventual solicitation and get on the agency's radar.
Pre-Solicitation	3–6 months out	Start your capture plan. Identify the program office contact. Begin teaming conversations.
Solicitation	15–45 days to respond	Decision time: bid or no-bid. Most primes shouldn't bid for the first time on a Solicitation they didn't track earlier.
Award Notice	Post-award	Read these for competitive intelligence — who won, at what price, for what scope. Free market research.

PRO TIP

The fastest path to your first federal award is responding to Sources Sought. Most small firms ignore them because there's no contract attached. The agencies who post them are signaling future demand, and they remember the firms who answer.

T01 • TROUBLESHOOTING

The six failure modes — and the exact fix for each.

Roughly 30% of first-time SAM registrations hit one of these six issues. Each has a known cause and a specific fix.

ISSUE	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
IRS validation fails	Legal name mismatch between SAM and IRS records	Call IRS Business Line at 800-829-4933. Get exact name on file. Update SAM. Resubmit; clears in 24–48 hours.
Registration stuck in 'pending'	CAGE code request still processing at DLA	Wait 5 business days. If still pending, call DLA CAGE at 1-877-352-2255 with your SAM request ID.
Can't find my entity after submit	Recently registered (<24 hrs) — SAM data refreshes overnight	Wait overnight. The Entity search index runs a nightly refresh.
Reps & Certs won't save	Browser compatibility — old Safari, Firefox, or browser extensions blocking scripts	Use Chrome or Edge. Disable ad blockers, password managers, and tracking blockers. Try incognito if it still fails.
EFT validation fails	Account or routing number mismatch with bank records	Re-type both numbers from a voided check. Banks merge often; old routing numbers fail. Confirm account is in your business legal name.
Login.gov locked out	Too many failed 2FA attempts	Use a backup code if you saved them. Otherwise login.gov support at 1-844-875-6446; allow 7 days for identity-verified recovery.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Federal contracting officers will not wait for your registration to clear. If they want to award and your SAM is inactive, they move to the next firm. Speed-to-fix on these issues is direct revenue protection.

T01 • ESCALATION PATHS

When the standard fixes don't work — who to call.

Some issues need a human at SAM, IRS, or DLA. Knowing the right phone number and the right thing to ask saves days.

The escalation directory

SYSTEM	PHONE	WHAT THEY HANDLE
Federal Service Desk (SAM)	866-606-8220	SAM technical issues, account access, role assignments, validation status. Open M–F 8am–8pm ET.
IRS Business & Specialty	800-829-4933	EIN verification, legal name confirmation, CP 575 / 147C replacement letters. Open M–F 7am–7pm local.
DLA CAGE Help Desk	877-352-2255	CAGE code assignment status, CAGE record updates, address changes.
Login.gov Help Desk	844-875-6446	2FA recovery, account lockouts, identity verification issues.
SBA HUBZone Help Desk	202-205-8885	HUBZone certification questions, employee residency verification.
VA Center for Verification	800-949-8387	SDVOSB / VOSB verification via VetCert.

FIELD TIP

Before you call, have your UEI, EIN, and the exact error message ready. Federal help desks can resolve most issues in one call if you give them the IDs. Without the IDs, they often need to escalate to a back office — which adds 3 to 5 days.

T02 • RENEWAL

Annual renewal — the 365-day rhythm that keeps you eligible.

SAM registrations expire every 365 days from activation. If you let it lapse — even by a day — you go inactive. No new awards. No payments on existing contracts. No invoice processing through Wide Area Workflow.

The 60/30/7 renewal cadence

WHEN	ACTION	WHO
60 days before expiration	Gather updated docs: latest fiscal year revenue, employee counts, current bank info, NAICS revisions. Pull a draft of the renewal form.	Operations + Finance
30 days before expiration	Update Reps & Certs — especially size status and socioeconomic claims. Re-verify legal name still matches IRS. Submit the renewal.	Entity Administrator + CFO
7 days before expiration	Confirm renewal cleared. If still pending, call Federal Service Desk. Do not let the clock run out.	Entity Administrator
Day of expiration	Verify 'Active' status in SAM. Confirm new expiration date is 365 days out.	Entity Administrator

What changes annually

- **Size status** — recalculate 3-year average revenue and 12-month average headcount. Update if you crossed a threshold.
- **NAICS list** — add codes for new service lines. Remove ones you no longer deliver.
- **POC info** — update if anyone left the company.
- **Bank info** — verify, even if unchanged. Confirm routing and account numbers are still correct.
- **Reps & Certs** — re-attest. Federal regulations change; the form may have new clauses.

THE GAP TRAP

If your registration goes inactive, every active federal contract pauses payment until you reactivate. Some agencies require a no-cost contract modification to resume work after a gap. The two-week reactivation window can cost you a full month of cash flow.

T02 • MID-YEAR CHANGES

What to update — and when — between renewals.

SAM is not a once-a-year activity. Some changes are required immediately. Others can wait for renewal. Knowing the difference keeps you compliant without creating busywork.

Changes that need immediate update

CHANGE	DEADLINE	WHY
Legal name change	Within 30 days	IRS records updated first, then SAM. Mismatches break payment processing.
Banking change	Before next invoice	Payments route to whatever bank record is current. Update before submitting the next invoice.
Address change	Within 30 days	Contracts may require notification. Some FAR clauses require the address used for performance.
Outgrowing size status	Within 5 business days of fiscal year-end	SBA rule. Continuing to claim small-business set-asides while large = False Claims Act exposure.
Loss of socioeconomic status	Within 5 business days	Loss of HUBZone (employees moved out), loss of veteran status (ownership change), loss of WOSB (woman owner sells) — all require immediate update.

Changes that can wait for renewal

- Adding secondary NAICS for service lines you've grown into.
- Updating POC titles (as long as the email still routes correctly).
- Refining your capability statement description.
- Adding optional fields like disaster response capability.

T03 • SECURITY LOCKDOWN

How to keep fraudsters off your bank record.

SAM-record takeover is the most common federal payment fraud. The pattern is straightforward: attacker phishes an Entity Administrator, logs into SAM with stolen credentials, changes the bank record to an account they control, and waits for the next government payment to land.

It happens because most SAM accounts are protected with the bare minimum. These six steps push you off the easy-target list.

The six-step lockdown

- 01 **Authenticator-app 2FA, not SMS.** SIM-swap attacks bypass SMS-based 2FA. Use Google Authenticator, Authy, or 1Password. Document the backup codes in your safe.
- 02 **Two Entity Administrators, not one.** Single admin = single point of failure. If they leave or get phished, you lose control. Two admins with 2FA reduce risk and give you a witness.
- 03 **Shared inbox, not personal email.** All login.gov and SAM notifications must hit an inbox the company owns and multiple people monitor.
- 04 **Set up SAM banking change alerts.** In your SAM profile preferences, enable email notification for any change to the bank record. If you ever see one you didn't initiate, call the Federal Service Desk immediately.
- 05 **Verify bank info every renewal.** Even if it hasn't changed. Read the routing and account numbers out loud against your bank's website.
- 06 **Restrict who has the Entity Administrator role.** Only people who must edit SAM should have the role. Auditors, accountants, BD staff — none of them need it.

WHY THIS MATTERS

In 2023, the GAO reported federal payment fraud losses ran into the hundreds of millions. Most cases traced back to compromised SAM Entity Administrator accounts. The fix is operational hygiene, not technology — which is why so many firms skip it.

T03 • INCIDENT RESPONSE

If you think your SAM record has been compromised.

If you see an unauthorized change to your SAM record — bank info changed, new POC added, Entity Administrator added — move fast. The longer the unauthorized change sits, the more likely a payment goes to the attacker.

The 60-minute response plan

MINUTE	ACTION	DETAIL
0–5	Lock SAM access	Change the login.gov password. Re-generate the 2FA secret. Revoke the existing 2FA device.
5–15	Call Federal Service Desk	866-606-8220. Report 'suspected unauthorized changes to SAM record.' Ask them to freeze the entity record pending investigation.
15–30	Notify your bank	Tell them to flag any incoming federal payment for verification. If a fraudulent payment already went out, they can sometimes recall it within 24 hours.
30–45	Notify your contracting officers	Email every CO you have an active contract with. Cc your contracts manager. Tell them the SAM record is under investigation; payments should be paused.
45–60	File a report	Submit to fraud.sba.gov and ic3.gov (FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center). Document everything in writing.

DOCUMENTATION

Take screenshots of the unauthorized changes immediately. Get the SAM change-history log. Save the IP addresses if SAM exposes them. This evidence supports your fraud claim with the bank, FBI, and SBA — and supports your defense if a payment gets clawed back from your firm.

WHAT'S NEXT

Active in SAM. Now **find** the work.

CapturePilot ingests every federal opportunity in your NAICS, scores them against your capability statement, and surfaces the Sources Sought notices that show real demand 6 to 18 months ahead of a Solicitation. Free 14-day trial. No card.

Get the full Federal Launch Kit →

[HTTPS://WWW.CAPTUREPILOT.COM/STARTUP-PACK](https://www.capturepilot.com/startup-pack)